

The Interpretation of Knowledge

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Editor's Introduction

Introduced by Elaine H. Pagels

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The Interpretation of Knowledge offers a unique opportunity to see how a gnostic teacher uses New Testament writings and applies them to the church. Features of style and structure suggest that the text presents a homily intended for delivery in a service of worship. The structure of the discussion follows a common pattern of worship, in which readings from the gospel are followed by readings from the apostle (that is, from Paul). Correspondingly, an early section of *The Interpretation of Knowledge* (9,21-14,15) uses passages known from Matthew to interpret the Savior's teaching and his passion; the following section (14,15-21,34) uses texts from 1 Corinthians and probably Romans, Colossians, Ephesians, and Philippians to interpret the church as the "body of Christ."

The author is concerned to address a community that is torn by jealousy and hatred over the issue of spiritual gifts. Some members refuse to share their spiritual gifts with one another; others envy those who have received such gifts as prophecy and public speaking and so stand out in the congregation. Some despise others whom they consider ignorant (that is, lacking gnosis); the rest feel slighted and resentful.

The author's concern throughout *The Interpretation of Knowledge* is to rectify this divisive situation. Having recalled how the Savior taught the oneness of the Father (9,28-29), and, further, how the "great Son" voluntarily accepted humiliation for the sake of his "small brothers" (14,28-29), he now applies the lessons of unity and of humility to the church. First he recalls how the church received redemption; the Savior abolished the "old bond of debt" which enslaved those "condemned in Adam" (14,34-36; cf. Cl 2:14) and proclaimed in its place the "edict of the Father" (14,29-31), offering forgiveness of sins and release from death (14,36-38). From 13,20 through 21,35 the author takes up Paul's metaphor of the body and its members (cf. Ro 12:4-8; 1 Co 12:12-31) and combines it with the images of Christ as the Head of the body, the church (cf. Cl 1:18; 2:19; Ep 4:15-16) in order to remind the members that they all share in the "same body" and the "same Head." Despite the diversity of gifts (cf. 1 Co 12:4), each member shares in the same grace (16,18-24; cf. Ro 12:6); the same power which inspires the speaker enables the listener to understand what he says (16,31-38). Those who receive lesser gifts are not to complain, but to rejoice that they also share in the body (18,28-38; 1 Co 12:14-26). Those who receive greater gifts, such as knowledge (gnosis; cf. 1 Co 12:8) are not to despise others as inferior or ignorant (17,25-26). On the contrary, "you are ignorant when you hate them" (17,27), for those who show hatred and jealousy toward others demonstrate by their attitude that they still resemble the jealous and ignorant demiurge. These attitudes betray their ignorance of God (15,30-33), the true Father, and of his Son.

Amplifying Paul's image of the church as a spiritual organism, the author takes up the metaphor of the plant with roots, branches, and fruits, "the roots have a connection with one another, and their fruits are undivided" (19,31-33). As the roots exist for the sake of the fruits and for another, "let us become like the roots, since we are equal" (19,36-37). The text concludes with warnings of persecution (20,20-38) and the exhortation to overcome sin; those who do overcome it shall receive a "crown of victory, even as our Head was glorified by the Father" (21,30-34).

The author, who identifies himself as a member of the church, shares scriptural texts and terms familiar to us from early Christian orthodoxy, while using Valentinian theology to interpret these to his audience. This teacher envisions the church he addresses as including both psychic and pneumatic Christians; he may have addressed this homily to both, or specifically to the small circle of the elect. This text offers a significant primary source for understanding how some Gnostic Christians—and specifically certain Valentinian Christians—understand the church in the light of Jesus' teaching and of Paul's letters.